

Week 2: Nigerian Peoples and Languages

JSS1 Nigerian History — First Term Lesson Note (Deep-Dive Edition)

Introduction

Nigeria is home to an extraordinary variety of peoples, cultures, and languages. This week surveys the major ethnic groups of Nigeria, where they are traditionally located, and the diversity of languages spoken across the country.

Major Ethnic Groups and Their Locations

Ethnic Group	Traditional Location
Hausa	North-western and north-central Nigeria (e.g., Kano, Katsina, Sokoto)
Fulani	Spread across northern Nigeria, historically semi-nomadic cattle herders
Yoruba	South-western Nigeria (e.g., Oyo, Ogun, Osun, Lagos, Ondo, Ekiti)
Igbo	South-eastern Nigeria (e.g., Anambra, Imo, Enugu, Abia, Ebonyi)
Kanuri	North-eastern Nigeria, around the Lake Chad area (Borno)
Edo (Bini)	South-central Nigeria (Edo State, around Benin City)
Ijaw	The Niger Delta region
Tiv	North-central Nigeria (Benue State and environs)
Ibibio/Efik	South-eastern coastal Nigeria (Akwa Ibom, Cross River)

Nigeria has over 250 ethnic groups in total. Hausa, Yoruba, and Igbo are often described as the three largest, but every ethnic group contributes its own distinct culture, language, and history to the nation.

Languages and Diversity

Nigeria is one of the most linguistically diverse countries in the world, with well over 500 languages spoken. Most Nigerian languages belong to the **Niger-Congo** language family (including Yoruba, Igbo, and most southern and central Nigerian languages), while Hausa belongs to the **Afro-Asiatic** family. English serves as Nigeria's official language, chosen in part because of the country's linguistic diversity, allowing communication across ethnic groups.

Real-Life Application

A student travelling from Lagos to Kano to Enugu would encounter Yoruba, Hausa, and Igbo as the dominant local languages respectively, alongside numerous smaller languages in each region — showing why English and Pidgin often serve as common languages of everyday communication across Nigeria.

Vocabulary

Word	Meaning
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Ethnic group	A community of people who share a common culture, language, and ancestry
Language family	A group of languages that share a common historical origin
Diversity	The state of having many different types or forms, such as many different peoples or languages

Evaluation Questions

- 1 Name the three largest ethnic groups in Nigeria and their traditional regions.
- 2 Where are the Kanuri people traditionally located?
- 3 Approximately how many languages are spoken in Nigeria?
- 4 Name the two major language families most Nigerian languages belong to.
- 5 Which language family does Hausa belong to?
- 6 Why does Nigeria use English as its official language?
- 7 Name one ethnic group found in the Niger Delta region.
- 8 Explain, in your own words, what “linguistic diversity” means.
- 9 Why might a country with many ethnic groups need a common official language?
- 10 List three ethnic groups other than Hausa, Yoruba, and Igbo, and their locations.